1,000-Year-Old Ghosts

By Laura Chow Reeve

KATIE: Popo taught me to pickle memories when I was thirteen. It's just like cucumbers, radishes, cabbage. I learned to cut them into even squares. Memories cut like apples; the knife slides through their protective skin with a crisp snap. I packed them in jars filled with salt, sugar, vinegar, and water. Adding herbs and spices can distort, make them harder to swallow.

POPO: It's a family secret. It allows you to forget.

KATIE: Forget what?

POPO: Anything. Forgetting does not come easily to the women in our family. We have our jars.

KATIE: What are we trying to forget, Popo?

POPO: So many questions. Chop this into smaller pieces.

INTRODUCTION

Forgetting is often the only way to survive, and it's almost inevitable due to the transitory/refugee nature of so many of our histories. But it has its price. 1,000-Year-Old Ghosts by Laura Chow Reeve is a beautiful, magical story about 3 generations of women wrestling with their painful

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memories. It highlights how many immigrants and those descended from them wrestle with the paradox of both wanting to hold on to the experiences that have made them and wanting to forget the pain that these memories have caused.

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KATIE: We started with minor moments: (1) When I dropped my underwear on the floor of the changing room after swim practice at school and Abigail Kincaid picked it up and showed the whole class. (2) The time I tugged on a strange woman's skirt in a Costco checkout line because I thought, for a second, that she was my mother. (3) A recurring nightmare of being alone in an abandoned building with no way to get out. After the lids were tightened . . .

POPO: How do you feel?

MOM: Ma, why are you teaching her that?

KATIE: It was a grey Sunday morning. It had been a bad week and I didn't want to remember any of it.

POPO: Because you won't.

KATIE: Do you have your own jars, Mom?

MOM: No.

KATIE: Like Popo, my mother was good at shutting down conversations. There were so many times that she felt far away. My arms could never quite reach her.

POPO: That's not true, Anne. We made you one or two when you were younger. You remember that.

KATIE: Mom wasn't looking at either of us. She was still holding a paper napkin she had used at breakfast. She was trying to smooth out the creases with her fingers. She opened her mouth to say something, but hesitated.

MOM: *(with tears in her eyes)* I'm sick of this. How come you decide what all of us remember or forget? You know what, Ma? I remember everything.

KATIE: My mother went through my room to find and display my jars on the kitchen counter. They confronted me when I got home from school, my mother and my jars.

MOM: I know Popo thinks this is best, but memories are important even when they are painful. I'm concerned about you. Both of you.

KATIE: I'm fine, Mom. Popo is fine.

MOM: She's not fine. I know she thinks she can control these things, but she can't. Her short-term memory is

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getting worse. She forgets where she puts things, she doesn't show up to appointments, she can't even tell me what she had for breakfast some days. Popo isn't fine.

KATIE: As I got older, I filled my jars with the things I had been holding onto. It was a feeling larger than relief -- a space to put myself away. (1) I chose to forget the white woman at the grocery store who told me I was prettier because I wasn't full Chinese. "You're so lucky," she said. (2) I chose to forget how my mother looked after the spindled cancer cells settled into her body. (3) I chose to forget the woman on the bus who spoke to me in Cantonese, and how I did not know how to respond. I searched for words that someone should have taught me, and I couldn't find them anywhere. *(Beat)* Popo never warned me not to let it become a habit, a practice, a daily ritual. Mom wasn't around to count my jars, display them, remind me of things I had already forgotten, witness my slow dissolve. My jars overflowed and spilled onto my hands until they stung. *(Beat)* [PoPo] drank a glass of saltwater every night before her evening prayers. When I asked why, she said

it was a leftover habit from when my Gung Gung ***(grandfather)*** would travel.

POPO: He died on his way back to China. Did you know that?

KATIE: You told me.

POPO: I just wanted to make sure you didn't forget. *(Katie opens one of PoPo's jars)*

POPO's MEMORY: *He is dying but refuses to die in America.*

GUNG GUNG: *I am going home. I cannot be buried here.*

POPO: *You are leaving me here. What am I supposed to do without you? What about Anne?*

GUNG GUNG: *What does it matter? I am dying either way. You don't want my ghost to haunt you. It's better for both of us if I go.*

To guarantee that she is not haunted by her dead husband, she stuffs most of what she has of him into thirty-seven glass jars. She only leaves enough to tell her future grandchildren (1) his name, (2) his occupation, (3) where he was born, (4) where he died.

KATIE: Popo? What do you put in your jars?

POPO: I don't remember. That is their purpose.

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KATIE: But aren't there things you wish you hadn't forgotten? I asked. She looked at me for a long time before she answered. *(Katie opens one of PoPo's jars)*

POPO'S MEMORY: *She never asks him about futures where he does not come back. She prays that he returns to her. He travels back and forth between their apartment in San Francisco and Southern China. It is rare to have a husband whose body tastes like the Pacific Ocean. It is rare to have a husband made mostly of salt.*

POPO's MEMORY: *The street outside their apartment is loud the way city streets tend to be. It drifts in through the open windows of their front room, and she lets it fill up the space he left behind. When he comes home, he shuts the windows and says he is tired of loud noises. He tells her how the ocean roars and the wind cracks. He tells her he has been looking forward to the silence of home.*

POPO: *(softly)* No. Sometimes I think there are not enough jars in this city for me to fill. Anne, grab me the measuring cups.

KATIE: Popo. I'm Katie. Anne was my mother. *(to audience)* Her eyebrows furrowed. The symptoms my

mother had witnessed in Popo years before had only gotten worse. She was shriveling. *(to PoPo)* Please stop. This is making you sick. *(to audience)* She continued to measure and chop; she licked her index finger, dipped it into a bowl of salt in front of her, and then popped it back in her mouth to taste.

POPO: I'm close.

KATIE: Close to what? What else could you have to forget?

(long silence)

POPO: I love you, but I wish I remembered how to say it the other way. *(she begins to cry)* There was a way I used to say it. I don't remember the words. I used to say it to someone. Do you remember?

KATIE: No, Popo. I don't. *(to audience)* She finished dissolving seven years after mom died. By the end, her slow pickling process had picked up speed. Everything I loved became smaller and smaller until she started to break apart in my hands. My memory was shaky. Most of the water in my body was salt. I no longer had difficulty forgetting; it came easily with or without a jar. Remembering was harder. *(Beat)* As I packed up her home, I looked for all the places that Popo had put

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herself to rest. I went through all of her drawers, her closets. I took every lid off of every box. Jars were hidden everywhere. She was right. There hadn't been enough jars in the city to hold everything she needed to put down. *(Katie opens one of PoPo's jars)*

POPO's MEMORY: *She is less lonely now that she has Anne. She has something to hold onto when she walks through Chinatown. She used to think that she would float away with nothing solid to hold her down. Now she walks with purpose. She teaches Anne how to say apple and block in English. She does not talk to her in Cantonese. When she does not know the word she is looking for in English she says nothing.*

(Katie opens another of PoPo's jars)

POPO's MEMORY: *Every time he comes back, he feels more foreign. He says "néih hóu ma," (some snow today) but she responds in English.*

GUNG GUNG: *One day Anne's children will not know how to speak our language.*

POPO: *Maybe that will be for the best. They will stop longing for things they cannot have. There will be no reason to leave. Not everyone can live in between*

things. Not everyone can survive being split into two.

There are fish that die in saltwater.

KATIE: I pulled on the [next] lid, but my hands kept slipping. I was too weak or the jar was too strong or whatever was inside didn't want to be taken back. I threw it against the wall. The glass shattered, the liquid dripped to the floor, the memory clung to the paint. Its smell surprised me— orange peels and baby powder. Popo was holding my mother's head in her lap, pushing her hair back with her hands, cooing to her softly.

One by one, I opened the rest of them. Sometimes they smelled rancid, like death. These were ones of her travels from China, her first few years living in San Francisco, my mother's sickness and funeral. Many of them smelled like the ocean, like Gung Gung's seawater breath, like the smells that made up her heartbreak.

The ones of me smelled like vanilla yogurt and strawberries . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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